

Distinguish a threat from a wish

Foundations

THE IDEA

A threat is a concrete action the opponent can carry out next if you do nothing. An attractive attacking arrangement is not necessarily a threat. Identifying the actual next move prevents both panic and neglect.

WORKED EXAMPLE

An enemy rook on an open file may look menacing. Ask where it can enter and what it would win. If every entry square is defended, you may have time for your own plan; if mate is threatened, you must react immediately.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

How do you test whether your opponent's last move created a threat?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Temporarily imagine making a harmless move. Find the opponent's strongest check, capture, or direct threat afterward. Then determine whether your real candidate prevents or outweighs it.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Name the threatened move and its consequence.